Lift Off and Miracle Workers

By Donovan Livingston and Taylor Mali

At the core, none of us were meant to be common.

We were born to be comets,

Darting across space and time —

Leaving our mark as we crash into everything.

INTRODUCTION

In 2016, Donovan Livingston delivered a convocation speech to the Harvard Graduate School of Education that went viral, reaching over 5 million people, and receiving national acclaim.

Livingston's message that day -- the boundless potential that lies within each child, the continuing fight for equity, and the transformative promise of education -- retains its power to challenge and elevate. And at a time when the existence of the American Department of Education balances on the knife's edge of existence, his words encourage and inspire students, educators, and communities to realize they have the power to change the shape of education, and to . . .

Lift Off by Donovan Livingston and Miracle Workers by Taylor Mali

Education then, beyond all other devices of human origin,

Is a great equalizer of the conditions of men."

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— Horace Mann, 1848.

At the time of his remarks I couldn't read, I couldn't write.

Any attempt to do so, punishable by death.

For generations we have known of knowledge's infinite power.

Yet somehow, we've never questioned the keeper of the keys —

The guardians of information.

Unfortunately, I've seen more dividing and conquering

In this order of operations — a heinous miscalculation of reality.

For some, the only difference between a classroom and a plantation is time.

How many times must we be made to feel like quotas —

Like tokens in coined phrases? —

"Diversity. Inclusion"

There are days I feel like one, like only —

A lonely blossom in a briar patch of broken promises.

But hey, I've always been a thorn in the side of injustice.

Disruptive. Talkative. A distraction.

With a passion that transcends the confines of my consciousness —

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Beyond your curriculum, beyond your standards.
I stand here, a manifestation of love and pain,
With veins pumping revolution.
I am the strange fruit that grew too ripe for the poplar tree.
I am a DREAM Act, Dream Deferred incarnate.
I am a movement — an amalgam of memories America would care to forget
My past, alone, won't allow me to sit still.
So my body, like the mind
Cannot be contained.
As educators, rather than raising your voices
Over the rustling of our chains,
Take them off. Un-cuff us.
Unencumbered by the lumbering weight
Of poverty and privilege,
Policy and ignorance.
I was in the 7th grade, when Ms. Parker told me,
"Donovan, we can put your excess energy to good use!"
And she introduced me to the sound of my own voice.
She gave me a stage. A platform.
She told me that our stories are ladders
That makes it easier for us to touch the stars.

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So climb and grab them.
Keep climbing. Grab them.
Spill your emotions in the big dipper and pour out your soul.
Light up the world with your luminous allure.
To educate requires Galileo-like patience.
Today, when I look my students in the eyes, all I see are constellations.
If you take the time to connect the dots,
You can plot the true shape of their genius —
Shining in their darkest hour.
I look each of my students in the eyes,
And see the same light that aligned Orion's Belt
And the pyramids of Giza.
I see the same twinkle
That guided Harriet to freedom.
I see them. Beneath their masks and mischief,
Exists an authentic frustration;
An enslavement to your standardized assessments.
At the core, none of us were meant to be common.
We were born to be comets,
Darting across space and time —

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Leaving our mark as we crash into everything.

A crater is a reminder that something amazing happened here —

An indelible impact that shook up the world.

Are we not astronomers – searching for the next shooting star?

I teach in hopes of turning content, into rocket ships —

Tribulations into telescopes,

So a child can see their potential from right where they stand.

An injustice is telling them they are stars

Without acknowledging night that surrounds them.

Injustice is telling them education is the key

While you continue to change the locks.

Education is no equalizer —

Rather, it is the sleep that precedes the American Dream.

So wake up, wake up! Lift your voices

Until you've patched every hole in a child's broken sky.

Wake up every child so they know of their celestial potential.

I've been a Black hole in the classroom for far too long;

Absorbing everything, without allowing my light escape.

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But those days are done. I belong among the stars.

And so do you. And so do they.

Together – together we can inspire galaxies of greatness

For generations to come.

No, no, sky is not the limit. It is only the beginning.

Lift off.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Donald Livingston
ISBN: 978-0399591372
Publisher: Random House Publishing
Date (Month/Year): April 2017
NOTE: Presented at the Harvard Graduate School of Education's 2016 Convocation -- May 25, 2016

AWARD HISTORY

2024 National Qualifier – MS

Miracle Workers (excerpt) by Taylor Mali

(Pg 53-55) I like to lecture on love and speak on responsibility.

I hold forth on humility, compassion, eloquence, and honesty.

And when my students ask,

"Are we going to be responsible for this?"

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I say, If not you, then who?
You think my generation will be responsible?
We're the ones who got you into this mess,
now you are our only hope.
And when they say, "What we meant to say
was, 'Will we be tested on this?'"
I say, Every single day of your lives!

Once, I put a pencil on the desk of a student
who was digging in her backpack for a pencil.
But she didn't see me do it, so when I walked
to the other side of the room and she raised her hand
and asked if she could borrow a pencil,
I intoned, "In the name of Socrates and Jesus,
and all the gods of teaching,
I declare you already possess everything you will ever
need!"
Shazzam!
"You are the weirdest teacher I have ever -- "
Then she saw the pencil on her desk and screamed.
"You're a miracle worker! How did you do that?"

I just gave you what I knew you needed

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before you had to ask for it.
Education is the miracle, I'm just the worker.
But I'm a teacher.
And that's what we do

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Author: Taylor Mali
Book: The Last Time as We Are, Pgs 53-55
ISBN: 978-0982148839
Publisher: Write Bloody Publishing
Date (Month/Year): Aug 2009

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